

The generals pounce

This was not the unequivocal pledge the South Vietnamese had been seeking from the US, but on November 1, the generals took action. Airborne and army troops backed up by some 40 tanks surrounded the presidential palace. While 150 presidential guards prepared to defend the palace, Diem called first Don and then Lodge. Neither gave him any comfort. Rejecting the generals' demands for his surrender, Diem escaped with his brother, Nhu, but they were soon captured. Despite promises of safe passage, they were brutally killed in the back of an armored car on November 2.

Diem and Nhu were buried in unmarked graves in Saigon's main Catholic cemetery.